

From Clicks to Streets: Quantifying the Spillover of E-Petitions into Physical Protests

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Abstract: Digital petitions ('slacktivism') are frequently criticized for creating low-effort engagement that fails to translate into substantive political pressure. This paper presents empirical findings tracking e-petition signatories over a 12-month period to measure conversion rates into physical demonstration and voting behavior.

1. Research Question

Research Question: What proportion of individuals who sign online environmental e-petitions participate in subsequent offline protests, and what factors predict offline behavioral conversion?

2. Empirical Methodology & Data Collection

Empirical Methodology & Data Collection: We conducted a 3-wave longitudinal panel study of 3,200 verified signatories of national environmental e-petitions launched in 2023. Survey waves measured prior political involvement, online engagement frequency, self-reported and verified event participation, and voting status in subsequent local elections. Response retention across all three waves reached 76.2% (n = 2,438).

Table 1: Empirical Findings Summary

Participation Level	Signatories (n=2,438)	Pct (%)	Offline Event Attended	Voter Turnout
E-Petition Only (Low-Effort)	1,414	58.0%	0 events	61.2%
E-Petition + Shared Media	634	26.0%	1–2 protests	74.5%
E-Petition + Offline Action	390	16.0%	3+ protests / rallies	88.9%

3. Discussion & Implications

Discussion & Conclusion: The empirical data demonstrates a 16.0% direct conversion rate from e-petition signing to sustained offline protest participation, with an additional 26.0% attending at least one physical demonstration. Rather than substituting for physical action, digital petitions function as an entry-level gateway in a tiered ladder of political participation, significantly elevating voter turnout among active online signers.